

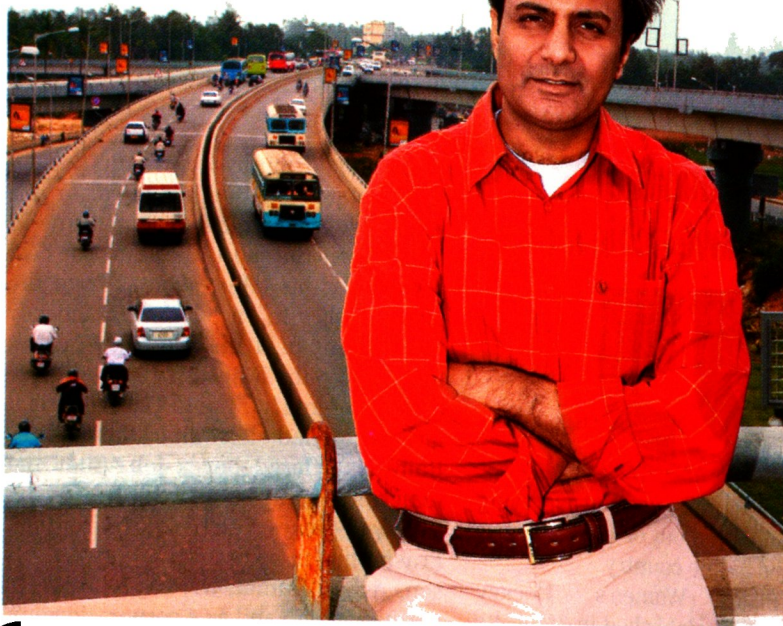
citizen FIRST

* **Ramesh Ramanathan, 44**

Project People's participation in public affairs

Can-do Icon People fuelled by a passion to overcome odds and reach their goals

India needs more than **Rs 1.2 trillion** of investment in urban infrastructure over the next seven years



The challenges are many. In a true democracy, a citizen should have a voice in the government.

RAMESH RAMANATHAN, Founder, Janaagraha

Managing a city is an incredibly complex job and no one has understood this better than the founder of Janaagraha in Bangalore. "The biggest problem is that most people think that the guys in charge are a bunch of jokers. The problem begins there," says Ramesh Ramanathan. Unlike a decade ago, the emphasis today is on urban India, the gateway

globalisation. It's one that Ramanathan has used as a revolving door. The Ramanathans (Ramesh and wife Swati) left India 20 years ago to pursue the American Dream. As managing director of Citibank's Equity Derivatives Business in Europe, Ramesh was being groomed to take over as CEO of Citibank. It was then that the couple decided that it was time to return to Bangalore, their

DEEPAK G PAWAR

story inspiring Ashutosh Gowariker in his making of Shah Rukh Khan-starrer *Swade*.

It was Swati who had noticed the efficient systems for citizen participation abroad during her stints in community work. This led to the question, why couldn't it be the same in India? "The first thing that was needed was to put a system in place. There was no point in complaining endlessly," says Ramanathan. Micro finance and public policy were his areas of interest and soon he was devising a fund-based accounting system for the Bangalore City Corporation, as part of the Bangalore Agenda Task Force (BATF) to invite corporate participation in public policy. The priority was to create a transparent system that allowed detailed listings of money allocated to each ward in the city for development work. The Ramanathans then founded Janaagraha, funded entirely by the Ramanathan Foundation with a corpus of Rs 2.5 crore. "It was a big deal 10 years ago but today everyone talks about advocacy because in a true democracy a citizen should have a voice in the government."

What started with creating a framework for accountability led to establishing mechanisms for participatory democracy and mandatory disclosure of financial performance by the local municipality. Each of Bangalore's 100 corporation wards citizens have a say and actively participate in the budget allocation of their wards. The challenges are many, from garbage disposal to the demand for housing. Ramanathan cites the traffic problems in cities as a classical example. "Is this because of bad roads or lack of an efficient mass transport system or too many private vehicles? The answer is, all of the above. We cannot treat each problem in isolation," he says. Finding solutions to such problems is what keeps Ramanathan and Janaagraha going. **by Nirmala Ravindra**